

Chapter 0

The Walk Out

The last paper always feels different when you know what went wrong.

Everyone else was walking out in groups -laughing, comparing answers, already planning where to eat. Arjun walked alone. Head down. Bag strap held tight across one shoulder like he was carrying something heavier than books.

He didn't want to talk to anyone.

Not because he was angry at them. He just had nothing to say. *How did it go? You okay?* The questions would come and he would have to answer them. He couldn't do that right now. So he turned left out of the gate and started walking toward the bus stand.

His mind wouldn't stop. Each scene just keeps flashing one after the other

Class six. Teacher going around the room asking each student -what do you want to become? Doctor. Engineer. Collector. IAS. When the teacher asked him he had said -*A successful person*. A few students laughed. The teacher smiled gently and moved on. Arjun hadn't minded. Arjun has actually meant it.

Class nine. Rajan uncle, his neighbour two houses down, suddenly collapsed one afternoon. Everyone panicked and worried. The doctor who stepped out of the ambulance -calm, certain, knowing exactly what to do, the doctor brought everyone out of that fear. The doctor had not only cured Rajan Uncle but had done something to Arjun (watching from his balcony) that he still couldn't explain properly. That night Arjun told his mother: I want to become a doctor. She said: then study. He studied.

Class eleven. A video going around in the class group. A hospital inauguration. A man speaking about building something bigger than himself. Naresh Trehan. Medanta. Arjun watched it four times. Something shifted. Not just *I want to help people* -something bigger. *I want to do something for this country*. He felt slightly embarrassed thinking it. It was the kind of thing people said in speeches. But he had felt it for real.

Then class twelve results. And the silence at home that nobody spoke about but everyone felt. The kind that sits at the dinner table and doesn't leave.

He had seen his father's face when the private medical college fee came on screen. Just one second. His father looked away quickly. But Arjun had already seen it.

He didn't apply.

He had found the CA idea almost by accident. A friend who had gotten 2 subjects back in 12th, whose family was pushing him toward CA. Arjun had looked it up that night. Then found a video -PM Modi speaking at some function to a room full of chartered accountants.

There was one line that made him stop scrolling.

Accountants are partners in nation building.

That same feeling from the Medanta video came back. And Pranav Bhaiya (his relative cum mentor) was a CA. Had been saying for years that CA was a serious profession, a real path. Arjun had trusted that.

He had enrolled.

And now here he was. Walking from the exam center to the bus stand after a paper that had taken something out of him. The entries he had practiced had disappeared under pressure. He had sat staring at one question for twenty minutes and couldn't begin.

Receptionist work, he thought. That's all it is. Debit this, credit that. This came in, that went out. Any person sitting at a counter can do this.

The thought sat heavy. He had left biology -the one subject that had actually made sense to him, where everything had a logic, where he had felt like he belonged -for this.

Partners in nation building.

It felt like a tagline now. Something said to fill a room with clapping.

He reached the bus stand and stopped.

The coaching institute across the road had put up a new banner. Big, bright, a little faded at the edges from the afternoon sun.

Congratulations to our AIR Rankers -Foundation & Intermediate.

Six photographs. Six faces. All smiling the particular smile of people who had cleared something hard and knew it.

Arjun looked at it for a moment.

These were supposed to be his people. His future. They looked like they had always known they were in the right room.

He looked away.

And then -without fully knowing why -he thought of Pranav Bhaiya.

Not warmly. More the way you think of the person who recommended something that didn't work out. Pranav Bhaiya had said CA was the right call. He was a CA himself -Fortune 500, finance, the whole picture that had made this choice feel safe two years ago.

Arjun found the contact. He called.

The Call

(Phone rings twice. Arjun is still standing at the bus stand, back to the banner, looking at the road.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Arjun? Bol, kya hua?

Arjun: Haan Bhaiya. Kaise ho?

(A pause. Pranav Bhaiya knows this voice. This is not how Arjun calls when things are fine.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Main theek hoon. Tu bata -paper kaisa gaya?

Arjun: *(quietly)* Theek tha.

Pranav Bhaiya: Arjun.

Arjun: Haan.

Pranav Bhaiya: Sach mein bata.

(Arjun exhales. Looks down at the road.)

Arjun: Bhaiya, aapko yaad hai -class six mein jab teacher poochti thi ki bade hokar kya banna hai?

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan.

Arjun: Main bolta tha -successful person banna hai. Tab se lekar class nine, ten, eleven -har baar kuch na kuch bada karna tha. Doctor banna tha. Phir Medanta wala video dekha aur laga ki yaar desh ke liye kuch karna hai. Itna bada sapna tha Bhaiya. Sach mein itna bada.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan, yaad hai mujhe.

Arjun: Aur aaj main yahan khada hoon bus stand pe. Foundation ka paper deke. Aur mujhe lag raha hai ki main galat jagah aa gaya hoon. *(stops)* Paise beech mein aa gaye Bhaiya. Bas isliye. Medical nahi ho paya. CA mein aa gaya. Aur aaj woh bhi *-(doesn't finish)*

Pranav Bhaiya: *(after a moment)* Tu successful person banna chahta hai — yeh abhi bhi hai?

Arjun: Haan. Woh toh hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Achha. Toh ek kaam kar -ek kahani sunata hoon. Socrates ke baare mein —

Arjun: *(cutting in, tired)* Bhaiya please. Motivate mat karo mujhe. Sach mein. Main us mood mein nahi hoon abhi. Jo bhi bologe nahi samjhunga. Please.

(Silence on the line. Pranav Bhaiya doesn't push. He understood something just now -this is deeper than a bad paper.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Theek hai. Koi baat nahi. *(pause)* Teri bus aayi?

Arjun: *(looking up)* Haan, aa gayi. Abhi board karni hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Chal, pehle chadh. Phir baat karte hain.

(Arjun boards the bus. Finds an aisle seat, middle of the bus. Settles in, bag on lap, phone back to his ear.)

Arjun: Haan Bhaiya, chadh gaya.

Pranav Bhaiya: Theek hai. Ek ek karke sawal puchta hoon -jawab dena. Okay?

Arjun: Haan bolo.

Pranav Bhaiya: Class 10th mein -kaisa feel hota tha tujhe? Andar se, apne liye?

Arjun: *(slightly surprised by the question)* Achha tha. Matlab topper nahi tha, aap jaise toh bilkul nahi -lekin marks theek the, concepts samajh aate the. Khush tha. Goal dikh raha tha -doctor banna hai, PCB padhni hai, bas karna hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Aur class 11th 12th mein?

Arjun: Woh toh aur bhi achha tha. Naya school, naye dost, roz kuch naya. Tab hi woh Medanta wala video dekha -aur laga ki sirf community ke liye nahi, desh ke liye sochna chahiye. Woh inspiration wahan se mili thi. *(pause)* Exam tak sab theek tha.

Pranav Bhaiya: Phir kya hua?

Arjun: *(quietly)* Aapko toh pata hi hai na ki kya hua.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. Par tu bata.

(Arjun looks out the window. The city is moving past -autos, chai stalls, people with somewhere to be.)

Arjun: Result achha tha. But topper nahi tha. Government college cut-off miss ho gaya. Private ka fee -*(stops)* Bhaiya aapko pata hai. Main nahi kar sakta tha. Ghar mein itna tha nahi. Maine dekha tha Papa ko jab fee screen pe aayi. Ek second ke liye. Unhone jaldi se nazar hataayi. Par main dekh chuka tha.

(Beat.)

Arjun: Maine apply hi nahi kiya.

Pranav Bhaiya: Phir CA ka idea kaise aaya?

Arjun: Ek dost tha. Usse 12th mein 2 subject me back laga tha. Uske ghar wale usse CA suggest kar rahe the. Usne bataya. Maine socha -dekh lete hain. Research ki thodi. Theek laga. *(pause)* Aur Bhaiya -ek video mila YouTube pe. PM Modi ka. Saare CAs se bhara hua room me woh speech dete hai.. Aur usme woh ek line ... "

Pranav Bhaiya: *(small laugh, cutting in between)* Haan, woh famous line. . "CA ki signature PM ki signature se bhi jyada powerful hoti hai.

Arjun: Nahi Nahi .. Woh line toh mujhe cliché lagi. Kaafi filmy. *(pause)* Par ek aur line thi uss video me - "Chartered Accountants are partners in nation building." Woh line sunke -Bhaiya, wahi feeling aayi jo Medanta wala video dekhke aayi thi. Wahi desh ke liye kuch karna wali feeling. Aur aap the -aap CA ho, aap bol chuke the ki yeh serious profession hai. Toh maine socha -haan, yeh karta hoon.

Pranav Bhaiya: Aur aaj -woh line kaisi lagti hai?

Arjun: *(short exhale, almost a laugh but not quite)* Marketing lagti hai Bhaiya. Bas taaliyaan bajwane ke liye boli gayi line. Accountants are partners in nation building -kaunsa nation building? Hum toh bas debit credit karte hain. Yeh aaya toh idhar likho, woh gaya toh udhar likho. Yeh toh hospital ka receptionist bhi karta hai -jo bhi aaya register mein likho, jo bhi gaya woh bhi likho. Itna hi toh hai. Itni badi baat kahan se aayi isme?

(Pranav Bhaiya doesn't react immediately.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Achha. Ek baat bata -Foundation mein char subject the. Sabse zyada boring, sabse zyada bekaar kaunsa laga?

Arjun: Accounts. Aur Law.

Pranav Bhaiya: Ek bata. Maine ek hi poochha.

Arjun: Accounts. Accounts toh bahut hi bekaar, boring subject lagta hai — law toh phir bhi samajh aata hai ki important hota hai business k liye.

Pranav Bhaiya: *(pauses)* Ek baat batayega mereko?

Arjun: Haan.

Pranav Bhaiya: Class 11th ke exams ke baad -12th shuru hone se pehle, beech ke gap mein -tu bahut beemaar pada tha. Typhoid. Yaad hai?

Arjun: *(shifting)* Haan. Kaun bhoolega woh.

Pranav Bhaiya: Kya kiya tha tab?

Arjun: Theek hi nahi ho raha tha bhai woh toh... Phir, Blood test karaya tha. Har teen din mein test hota tha. Doctor report dekhta tha, ussi se medicine change karta tha. Dheere dheere theek hua. Poore 15 din lage the.

Pranav Bhaiya: Theek hone ka asli karan kya tha?

(Arjun thinks for a second, not sure where this is going.)

Arjun: Woh... blood test report. Doctor ussi ke basis pe sab decide kar raha tha. Kaunsi medicine, kitna rest, kya khana kya nahi. Sab ussi report se aa raha tha.

Pranav Bhaiya: Exactly. Ab bata -agar woh blood test report hi galat hoti? Numbers hi galat hote? Toh kya doctor sahi se treat kar paata?

Arjun: Nahi. Obviously nahi. Galat report pe galat treatment hoti.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul. *(a beat)* Arjun -jo insaan accounts banata hai — woh usi company ka blood test report bana raha hota hai. Bahar se company kaisi bhi dikhe -news mein, ads mein, logon ke mann mein -company ka asli haal kya hai, woh sirf us balance sheet mein, us profit and loss mein, us cash flow statement mein hota hai. Woh uska blood report hai. Aur jaise tera blood report galat hota toh tera sahi ilaaj nahi ho sakta tha - agar kisi company ka financial statement galat ho, toh uske saath jo bhi decisions lene wale hain — bank, investors, government -sab ke sab galat ho jaayenge.

(The bus hits a pothole. A man sitting ahead gets up -his stop. Arjun slides over and takes the window seat. Cool air comes in.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Kya hua? Chup kyu Hogaya?

Arjun: *(settling in)* Nahi Bhaiya -bas woh seat mein baith gaya hoon ab. Window seat mili. *(pause, then quieter)* Aap aage boliye.

Pranav Bhaiya: Toh ek accountant ka role -receptionist ka nahi hota, Arjun. Pathologist ka hota hai. Jo uss company ka blood report banata hai -jiske basis pe sab kuch decide hota hai. Use Investors, Employees, government, banks, Vendors, Customers sab ka decision kahin na kahin uss Blood report (uss Company k Financials) se judi hoti hai.

(Arjun is quiet. Outside, the city is thinning. The road is getting wider.)

Arjun: *(after a moment)* Achha.

(He looks out the window. Just that one word. But something has shifted.)

The Blood Report of a Business

(Outside, the city is thinning. The road is getting wider. Arjun is watching it from the window, phone still at his ear.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Arjun, ek baat bata. Ek simple sawaal . Ek business ka -koi bhi business ho -uska blood report kaisa dikhega? Matlab, agar ek company ka bhi blood test hota, toh usme kya kya hota?

Arjun: *(frowning)* Business ka blood test? Bhaiya company koi insaan nahi hoti. Blood test toh uske owner ka hoga na?

Pranav Bhaiya: Sahi poochha. Pehle yeh bata -company aur uska owner — dono alag hote hain ya ek?

Arjun: *(flatly, like reciting)* Alag hote hain. Business entity concept. Padha hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul. Toh company ko ek alag insaan maan lo. Bilkul alag. Apni pehchaan, apna haal, apna sab kuch alag. Owner alag, company alag. Jab company ki baat karte hain toh sirf company ki baat karte hain.

Arjun: *(sarcastically)* Achha. Toh Bhaiya -yeh company kya khaana khaati hai? Uska RBC, WBC hota hai kya? Haemoglobin hota hai?

Pranav Bhaiya: *(without missing a beat)* Haan. Hota hai.

(Arjun blinks.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Company khaana khaati hai -uska khaana hota hai income aur revenue. Jaise ek insaan ko vitamins, glucose chahiye hota hai energy ke liye — waise company ko income chahiye hoti hai chalte rehne ke liye. Jis din income aani band ho gayi, company waise hi girne lagti hai jaise ek insaan jise khaana milna band ho jaaye.

Arjun: Okay. Theek hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Aur jaise ek insaan khaana kha ke bahut saari activities karta hai -school jaata hai, cricket khelta hai, ghumne jaata hai -waise company bhi apni income se bahut saare kaam karti hai. Salary deti hai, bijli ka bill bharta hai, raw material kharidti hai. Yeh sab uske expenses hain.

Arjun: Matlab income minus expenses -net mein kya bachha woh profit ya loss.

Pranav Bhaiya: Exactly. Aur jaise mummy bolti hain na -zyada khelo toh thak jaoge, pehle kuch khaa lo, energy aayegi -waise business mein bhi itna hi kharcho jitna kamaate ho. Zyada thak gaye toh health kharab.

Arjun: *(small smile, almost involuntary)* Aur company jyada khele toh Net loss ho jaata hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul. Ab aage bata -ek insaan ke paas sirf income aur expense hi nahi hoti na? Kuch permanent cheezein bhi hoti hain. Ghar hota hai, gaadi hoti hai, savings hoti hain.

Arjun: Haan.

Pranav Bhaiya: Waise hi company ke paas bhi permanent cheezein hoti hain. Inhe hum assets bolte hain. Aur tu biology ka student hai toh tere language me hi samjha deta hoon. *(pause)* Company ke paas jo building hai, machinery hai, equipment hai -yeh sab uski haddiyan aur muscles hain. Bones structure dete hain, muscles kaam karte hain -waise property aur machinery company ko structure deti hai future economic benefit deti hai. Dono umar ke saath thakti hain -isi liye hum depreciation lete hain. Waise hi jaise haddiyan aur muscles umar ke saath kamzor hoti hain.

Arjun: *(nodding slowly)* Okay. Yeh toh samajh aaya.

Pranav Bhaiya: Ab -tune glycogen padha hai na biology mein?

Arjun: Haan. Stored glucose. Body mein store rehta hai, baad mein energy ke liye use hota hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Wahi hoti hai company ki inventory. Raw material, stock — abhi store hai, baad mein jab bikegi toh cash aayega, income aayegi. Abhi ka glycogen, kal ka glucose.

Arjun: Aur cash?

Pranav Bhaiya: Cash hai free flowing glucose. Abhi hai, abhi use ho sakta hai. Koi conversion nahi, koi wait nahi. Seedha kaam aata hai.

Arjun: Aur investments jo books mein hote hain?

Pranav Bhaiya: Bone marrow. Body mein ek deep reserve hota hai -koi bada accident jaisa ho jaaye toh bone marrow se blood banta hai, body sambhal leti hai. Company ke investments waise hi hain -daily use mein nahi hain, par kisi badi zaroorat ke waqt kaam aate hain. Future ke liye rakhe hue hain.

(Arjun is quiet for a moment. Looking out the window. The fields have started — they are past the city now.)

Arjun: Bhaiya -baat toh sahi bol rahe ho. *(pause)* Aur liabilities? Woh bhi kuch hota hai body mein? Woh kharaab wala -urea, creatinine -woh sab?

Pranav Bhaiya: Kuch liabilities haan, waise hoti hain -penalty, doubtful debts, koi purana bura obligation. Woh sach mein waste products hain, jitna jaldi niklo utna achha. Par Arjun -har liability kharab nahi hoti. Yeh samajhna zaroori hai.

Arjun: Matlab?

Pranav Bhaiya: Socho -agar kisi customer ne advance mein paisa de diya. Tune kaam abhi kiya nahi, deliver nahi kiya -par paisa aa gaya. Toh yeh liability hai books mein. Par yeh kharab hai kya? Nahi. Yeh toh income banne wali hai -bas thoda wait karo jab tak kaam poora na ho. Jaise khaana khaaya par abhi pacha nahi -digestive tract mein hai. Energy abhi nahi bani, thodi der mein banegi. Woh burden nahi hai -woh process mein hai.

Arjun: Aur loan? Woh toh liability hi hota hai na -woh kharab nahi hota?

Pranav Bhaiya: Depends. Loan lekar agar achi machinery kharid li, jo aage chal ke income degi -toh woh loan ek carrier ki tarah kaam kiya. Resources sahi jagah pahunchaye. Kharaab tab hota hai jab loan liya aur kuch productive nahi kiya usse -sirf interest bhar rahe ho, koi output nahi. Woh sach mein burden hai. Toh liability ko hamesha poochho -yeh kya kar rahi hai system mein? Kaam aayegi ya sirf daba ke rakhegi?

(Arjun absorbs this. Looks back out the window.)

Arjun: *(slowly)* Toh balance sheet mein jo assets hain woh company ki haddiyan hain, muscles hain, glucose hai, bone marrow hai -aur liabilities mein kuch useful hain, kuch waste. Aur jo difference bachha -assets minus liabilities -woh company ki apni value hai. Net worth.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul sahi.

Arjun: *(after a pause)* Par Bhaiya -yeh sab toh bas classification hi hai na? Matlab iss cheez ko isme daalo, iss cheez ko isme classify kardo. bas khatam. Isme nation building jesi kya baat ho gayi ab? Accountant ne BS PL banayi, owner ne dekhi, baat khatam? aur koi padhta bhi hai inko? Kisi aur ko kya matlab inka?

(Pranav Bhaiya pauses. This is exactly the question he was waiting for.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Yeh sawaal poochha tune -bahut achha poochha. Iska jawab hi batayega ki ek accountant ka role kitna bada hai. *(pause)* Bata -jab tera typhoid tha, tera blood report sirf teri mummy dekhti thi kya?

Arjun: Nahi. Doctor dekhta tha. Papa dekhte the. School me bhi submit hua tha. Teachers ne dekha tha, to check fitness report.

Pranav Bhaiya: Exactly. Ek insaan ka blood report -ek patient ke liye — uske doctor ne dekha, ghar walon ne dekha, sab ne decisions liye ussi ke basis pe. Par woh ek insaan ka report tha -sirf ek patient.

Ab socho -ek badi company ka financial report. Ek bank jab usse loan dene ka sochta hai -woh kya dekhta hai? Wahi balance sheet. Itni takkat hai ki loan chuka payegi ya nahi -woh blood report se pata chalta hai. Ek bada investor jo stock market mein paisa lagaana chahta hai company mein -woh kya dekhta hai? Wohi P&L, wohi balance sheet. Company ki health kaisi hai -woh report se samajhta hai. Government jab decide karti hai ki kisi company ko koi scheme ka benefit milega ya nahi -woh financial statements dekhti hai.

(a beat)

Pranav Bhaiya: Ek insaan ke blood report ka ek reader hota hai -doctor, ghar wale. Ek company ke financial report ke readers hote hain -banks, investors, government, employees, vendors, customers -poora ek chain. Aur badi companies toh har teen mahine mein apna blood report nikalti hain. Isko hum interim financial reporting bolte hain.

Arjun: *(quietly, almost to himself)* Matlab yeh report sirf owner ke liye nahi hoti.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul nahi. Yeh toh sab ke liye hoti hai. Aur isliye jo insaan (woh accountant) jo yeh report banata hai -uski zimmedari sirf owner tak nahi rukti, uske upar inn sab ka biswas tika hua hota hai. Unke decisions hote hai iss financials ke base pe.

(Outside, a flock of birds crosses the open sky. The bus moves steadily. Arjun is very still.)

The Classification Problem

Arjun: Par Bhaiya -yeh sab toh easy hai na ultimately? Matlab jo aap bata rahe ho -asset hai, liability hai, income hai, expense hai. Classify karo aur likh do. Debit idhar, credit udhar. Itni importance kyun hai isme? Ek pathologist ki report mein bhi toh seedha count aata hai -haemoglobin kitna hai, WBC kitna hai. Woh bhi toh classify karta hai. Accounts mein aisa kya mushkil hai jo itna important ban jaata hai?

(Pranav Bhaiya is quiet for a moment. Not because he doesn't have an answer — because he wants Arjun to feel the question before he answers it.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Tu biology ka student hai. Ek cheez poochhta hoon. PAS stain -padha hai?

Arjun: Haan. Periodic Acid Schiff. Glycogen ke liye use karte hain.

Pranav Bhaiya: Woh kaam kya karta tha exactly?

Arjun: *(thinking back)* Stored glycogen hai ya active metabolism ho rahi hai -yeh differentiate karta tha. Liver functioning ke baare mein pata chalta tha. Slide pe daag aata tha -magenta colour -aur ussi se pata chalta tha ki glycogen ka kya haal hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Aur sabse badi dikkat kya thi usme?

Arjun: *(slowly)* Dono ek jaise dikhte the. Stored glycogen aur active glucose metabolism -slide pe same colour, same pattern. Bahut baariki se dekhna padta tha. Ek extra step hota tha -diastase digestion -jo glycogen ko tod deta tha pehle staining se. Agar woh step skip karo toh stored glycogen bhi active jaisi dikhti thi. Galat result aata tha.

Pranav Bhaiya: Exactly correct. *(pause)* Arjun -accounts mein bhi bilkul wahi hota hai. Ek paisa aaya company ke paas. Cash account mein dikha. Ab sawaal yeh hai -kya yeh income hai? Ya kuch aur hai?

Arjun: *(carefully)* Depend karta hai. Agar customer ne advance diya hai toh income nahi -liability hai. Abhi kaam nahi hua, toh earn nahi kiya.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul. Same substance -paisa. Par classification alag. Ek case mein income, ek case mein liability. Aur agar galat classify kar diya — toh blood report galat ho gaya. Wahi PAS stain wali galti. Dono ek jaise dikhte hain -par ek active hai, ek stored hai. Ek earn kiya hua hai, ek abhi bhi obligation hai.

(A pause. Arjun is leaning slightly toward the window now, not away from the conversation.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Ek real example deta hoon. Tujhe yaad hai -class 8, 9, 10 mein tu Byju's use karta tha?

Arjun: *(surprised)* Haan. Papa ne liya tha. Sales wala bahut convincing tha. Aapne mana kiya tha tab -par unhone le liya. EMI pe. Teen saal ki fees ek saath.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. Maine mana kiya tha. *(small pause)* Teen saal ka course tha. Paisa poora ek saath liya -discount ke liye. Ab socho -Byju's ke accountant ke paas woh paisa aa gaya. ₹90,000. Ek baar mein. Ab yeh paisa kya hai?

Arjun: *(thinking)* Teen saal ka hai. Toh ek saal mein sirf ₹30,000 ka kaam deliver hoga. Baaki do saal ka abhi deliver nahi kiya. Toh ₹60,000 toh liability hai -advance receive kiya, performance abhi baaki hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul sahi. Yahi IndAS 115 kehta hai -revenue tab recognize karo jab performance obligation पूरी हो. Jab kaam actually deliver ho. Yeh wahi diastase step hai -pehle check karo ki yeh earned hai ya stored. Earned hai toh income. Stored hai -abhi bhi obligation hai -toh liability.

Arjun: Aur Byju's ne?

Pranav Bhaiya: Byju's ne woh poora ₹90,000 usi saal income mein book kar liya. Teen saal ka paisa, ek saal mein. PAS stain kiya -par diastase step skip kar diya. Glycogen ko glucose bol diya. Stored ko earned bol diya.

(Beat.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Aur yeh company ne ek saal nahi kiya -yeh saalon tak hota raha. Har saal nayi enrollments, har saal unka poora paisa usi saal income. Revenue ke numbers extraordinary dikhne lage. Valuation \$22 billion tak pahunchi. Investors aaye. Lenders aaye. Sab ne us blood report ko dekha aur trust kiya.

Arjun: *(quietly)* Par woh report hi galat thi.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul galat thi. Aur jab real earned revenue nikala — jo actually deliver ho chuka tha -woh bahut kam tha. Company ko naye enrollments chahiye the sirf isliye ki purane obligations cover ho sakein. Jab growth ruki -cash khatam ho gaya. Salary default hui. Lenders ne cases kiye. Customers ne suffer kiya. Teen bade auditors ne ek ke baad ek resign kar diya.

Arjun: Teen auditors?

Pranav Bhaiya: Deloitte, BDO, Grant Thornton -teeno ne alag alag waqt resign kiya. Koi apna naam nahi lagaana chahta tha us report pe. Jaise teen independent labs ek ke baad ek refuse kar den -"hum is report ko certify nahi karenge." Yeh signal kya deta hai?

Arjun: *(slowly)* Ki patient bahut serious condition mein hai. Aur koi confirm karne ko taiyaar nahi.

Pranav Bhaiya: Exactly. Aaj Byju's ki valuation zero hai. Founder ke upar cases hain. Aur un logon ka paisa gaya -investors, lenders -aur Arjun, teri tarah ke students ke parents ka paisa bhi gaya. Tera ₹90,000. Jo EMI pe liya tha. Woh bhi gaya.

(Arjun goes quiet. This is not abstract anymore. He remembers the Samsung tablet he got from ByJu's. The classes he never finished. The phone call he and his mom did to Customer support for refund, but was never answered. His father's face when the company started collapsing in the news.)

Arjun: *(after a moment)* Itni badi company. \$22 billion. Aur galti kya thi? Ek basic si classification mistake.

Pranav Bhaiya: Ek basic si classification mistake -jo saalon tak chalti rahi. Jisko rokna ek responsible accountant ka kaam tha. Initial years mein hi agar kisi ne rok diya hota -"Sir, yeh revenue 3 saal ka hai, hum sirf ₹30,000 is saal dikhayenge" -toh shayad company aaj hoti. Shayad lakhon students ko achha platform milta rehta. Par kyunki woh ek step skip hua -diastase step — poora khel bigad gaya.

(Arjun is staring out the window. The evening sky has turned orange at the edges.)

Arjun: *(slowly)* Jisko main receptionist ka kaam bol raha tha, woh toh....

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. *(quietly)* Aur Arjun -yeh sirf Byju's ki baat nahi hai. Jab ek badi company doobti hai -uska asar sirf us company tak nahi rehta. Byju's doobi toh bahar ke investors ka India pe se bharosa uth gaya. "Is desh mein safe investment nahi hai" -yeh baat gayi duniya mein. Ek company ki galat blood report ne poore desh ki credibility pe daag lagaya.

Bahar se Byju's kya tha? IPL sponsor. Messi sponsor. India ka biggest unicorn. Andar se? Blood report kabhi sahi tha hi nahi.

(A long pause.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Ek insaan ka blood report galat ho -ek patient ko khatara. Ek company ka financial statement galat ho -ek poori chain ko khatara. Bank ne galat report dekhke loan diya. Fund house ne galat report dekhke

invest kiya. Government ne galat report dekhke decisions liye. Aur woh 18 saal ka ladka jisne pehli baar paisa invest kiya -usne bhi wahi galat report dekhi thi.

Arjun: *(very quietly)* Ek report. Itne saare log.

Pranav Bhaiya: Ek blood report ka ek reader hota hai. Ek financial report ke readers hote hain -ek poora desh. Aur jo insaan woh report banata hai -woh akela baitha hota hai apni screen ke saamne, journal entries karta hua -usse kabhi pata nahi chalta ki kitne log uski ek entry pe depend kar rahe hain.

(The bus moves. Arjun says nothing for a while. Outside, the last of the city has disappeared completely. Just open road, open sky, and the orange of evening.)

Arjun: *(after a long silence)* Bhaiya -ek baat bolunga.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bol.

Arjun: Jis din maine CA choose kiya tha -woh "partners in nation building" wali line sunke kiya tha. Tab sirf ek feeling thi -desh ke liye kuch karna hai. Kya karna hai, kaise karna hai -nahi pata tha. *(pause)* Aaj pehli baar samajh aaya ki woh line actually kya kehti hai. Ki agar main kisi badi company ka accountant banunga aur sahi report banaunga -toh main actually kuch kar raha hoon. Kisi ko pata nahi chalega. Par ho raha hoga.

(Pranav Bhaiya doesn't say anything immediately. He lets it sit.)

Pranav Bhaiya: *(quietly)* Haan.

(Just that. One word. Enough.)

One Question Arjun Didn't Expect to Ask

(The bus is moving steadily. Outside it is getting dark at the edges. Arjun is quiet -not the heavy quiet from before, something lighter. He is looking out the window. Thinking.)

Arjun: Bhaiya -ek cheez poochhni thi. Personal.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bol.

Arjun: Aap Fortune 500 mein ho. CA ho. Sab kuch hai jo log kehte hain successful hone ke liye chahiye. Toh -kya aapko lagta hai aapne apna sapna paa liya? Jo aap class 6, 8, 10 mein sochte the -woh wali success mil gayi?

(A pause. Longer than usual.)

Pranav Bhaiya: *(slowly)* Wese toh... haan bhi. Aur naa bhi.

(Arjun waits. Doesn't push.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Company achhi hai. Kaam achha hai. Paisa theek hai. Bahar se sab set lagta hai. *(pause)* Par woh... woh jo feeling thi na — ki haan, yeh wahi hai jo chahiye tha -woh abhi bhi nahi aayi poori tarah. Pata nahi exactly kya chahiye tha. Pata nahi exactly kya miss ho raha hai. Success ka matlab kya hai -yeh definition meri apni abhi bhi badal rahi hai. Aaj bhi.

(A short silence. Something in Pranav Bhaiya's voice is different -quieter, more careful. Like he didn't plan to say that.)

Arjun: *(gently)* Koi baat nahi Bhaiya. Kabhi aur baat karte hain iske baare mein.

Pranav Bhaiya: *(recovering, quietly)* Haan. Kabhi aur. *(small pause)* Par yeh sawaal tune poochha -aur yeh sawaal important hai. Apne liye bhi soch lete rehna. Success ka matlab kya hai -yeh answer kisi ke paas ready nahi hota. Banana padta hai.

(Brief silence. Both of them sitting with that for a moment.)

The Law Nobody Invented

(The bus is steadily moving. Outside it is almost fully evening now. Arjun is relaxed in the window seat -not happy, not sad. Just present. Thinking.)

Arjun: Bhaiya -par ek cheez abhi bhi samajh nahi aayi.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bol.

Arjun: Yeh jo poora system hai -balance sheet alag, P&L alag, cash flow alag. Teen alag statements. Ek hi blood report mein sab kyun nahi? Aur yeh double entry ka concept -debit aur credit, har cheez ka dono taraf entry — yeh kya hai exactly? Matlab balance sheet hamesha balance hoti hai -yeh toh mujhe bahut gimmicky lagta hai. Koi bhi company kitni bhi mushkil mein ho — balance sheet balance rahegi? Body toh hamesha balanced nahi rehti. Company bhi toh kharab hoti hai, doobti hai -toh balance kaise rehta hai hamesha? Yeh koi gimmick hai kya?

Pranav Bhaiya: *(slowly)* Arjun -tu biology ka student hai isiliye maine tujhe biology ke angle se samjhaya kyunki woh tera background tha. Par yeh jo double entry ka sawaal hai -yeh biology ka sawaal nahi hai. Yeh bahut badi principle hai.

Arjun: Matlab?

Pranav Bhaiya: Tune Newton ka Third Law padha hai?

Arjun: Haan. Every action has an equal and opposite reaction, invented by Newton.

Pranav Bhaiya: Newton ne yeh law invent kiya tha?

Arjun: *(automatically)* Haan *-(stops)* matlab... discover kiya tha.

Pranav Bhaiya: Exactly. Discover. Invent nahi. Yeh law pehle se tha — universe mein, creation ke pehle din se. Newton ne sirf dekha. Notice kiya. Likha. Naam diya. Par law usse pehle bhi tha, uske baad bhi rahega. Yeh universe ka niyam hai -koi action ek taraf nahi hota. Har action ka equal aur opposite reaction hota hi hota hai. Hamesha. Bina exception ke.

(A brief silence.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Yeh pattern sirf physics mein nahi hai. Chemistry mein equation balance hoti hai -atoms in equal atoms out. Biology mein homeostasis -body mein koi bhi shift aaye, compensating response automatically aata hai. Economics mein -har buyer ke liye ek seller hona hi chahiye. Yeh sab ek hi cheez bol

rahe hain alag alag languages mein — koi bhi event ek akela event nahi hota. Har event ke hamesha do sides hote hain. Hamesha.

Arjun: *(carefully)* Dono sides.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. Kuch create hota hai -aur kuch experience hota hai. Dono simultaneously. Ek hi waqt mein. Yeh alag nahi ho sakte.

(pause)

Pranav Bhaiya: Yahi double entry hai. Balance sheet capture karta hai jo create hua -kya bana, kya accumulate hua, kya exist karta hai. Aur P&L capture karta hai jo experience hua -kya kamaya, kya kharch hua, kya result nikla. Yeh dono ek hi event ke do faces hain, equal and opposite. Isliye balance sheet hamesha balance hoti hai -yeh koi accounting trick nahi hai. Yeh universe ka wahi नियम hai jo Newton ne force aur motion ki language mein likha tha.

(Arjun goes very still.)

Pranav Bhaiya: 1494 mein ek Italian mathematician tha -Luca Pacioli. Usne double entry system ko document kiya. Par usne invent nahi kiya tha. Usne notice kiya tha -ki commerce ki duniya mein bhi wahi law kaam karta hai jo physics mein kaam karta hai. Har transaction ke hamesha do sides hote hain. Hamesha equal. Hamesha opposite. Usne sirf likha.

(Long pause. Outside, a few lights have come on in distant houses. The sky is deep blue now at the top, orange at the horizon.)

Pranav Bhaiya: *(quietly, letting it land)*

Yeh universe ka नियम hai -business ki language mein likha hua. Jaise Newton ka Third Law likha hua hai force aur motion ki language mein.

(Silence on the line. Not awkward silence -the kind that comes when something actually lands.)

Arjun: *(very quietly)* Matlab... Pacioli ne wahi kiya jo Newton ne kiya. Dono ne kuch invent nahi kiya. Dono ne sirf dekha jo pehle se tha. Newton ne force and motion ke language me samjhaya and pacioli ne same law , business k language me.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan.

Arjun: *(after another pause, a small disbelieving laugh)* Bhaiya — aapne toh accounts ko Newton se hi relate kar diya.

Pranav Bhaiya: Maine nahi kiya. Woh hamesha se hi tha. Kisi ne notice nahi kiya tha bas.

Arjun: *(slowly)* Aur balance sheet hamesha balance rehti hai -even when company doob rahi ho -kyunki woh universe ka नियम reflect kar rahi hai. Bankrupt company mein equity negative ho jaayegi -par equation phir bhi hold karegi. Assets equal liabilities plus equity. Minus equity ke saath bhi.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul sahi. Yeh system kabhi jhooth nahi bolta. Condition chahe kuch bhi ho.

Arjun: *(after a moment, genuinely)* Bhaiya -aap toh accounts ke Newton nikle. Seriously.

Pranav Bhaiya: *(laughs quietly)* Main toh bas ek experienced Accountant hoon jo iss waqt ek frightened biology student ko samjhaa raha hoon.

Arjun: Nahi sach mein -aapne Newton ke law ke angle se poora double entry ka doubt hi clear kar diya.

Pranav Bhaiya: *(still smiling)* Theek hai. Par pehle aage suno -abhi ek aur cheez baaki hai.

Arjun: Kya?

Pranav Bhaiya: Tune abhi jaana ki business me double entry system hota hai. Kya tujhe pata hai -hamare life me bhi double entry system work kar raha hota hai. Ek human being ka bhi P&L hota hai, balance sheet hoti hai, cash flow statement hota hai!

(Arjun turns from the window and frowns -genuinely confused, genuinely curious.)

Arjun: Insaan ka BS n PNL?

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. Agar tune yeh samajh liya -toh company ka sab kuch automatically samajh aa jaayega. Kyunki dono ek hi law follow karte hain.

(Outside, the first star has appeared. Arjun doesn't notice it. He is listening.)

The Balance Sheet of a Human Being

(Arjun has turned from the window. Genuinely curious now.)

Arjun: Insaan ka balance sheet? Matlab?

Pranav Bhaiya: Socho -humari zindagi mein kya hota hai? Bahut saare events hote hain. Bahut saare experiences hote hain. Bahut saare actions lete hain hum. Har din. Saalon tak.

Arjun: Haan.

Pranav Bhaiya: Jaise COVID aaya -ek event tha. Kisi ke liye business badh gaya, kisi ka dub gaya. Ek hi event -alag alag experience. Aur jaise ek business ne kisi doosri company se kuch kharida -ek ka revenue, doosre ka expense. Same transaction, do alag sides. Yeh universe ka wahi niyam hai jo hum abhi baat kar rahe the -koi bhi cheez sirf ek taraf nahi hoti.

Arjun: Haan -equal and opposite.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul. Ab socho -ek insaan ke jo experiences hote hain, jo events hote hain, jo actions hote hain -inhe hum record karein toh kya hoga? Ek insaan ka P&L kya hoga?

Arjun: *(thinking)* Jo achhe experiences hue -woh income side? Aur jo nahi achhe the -expense?

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. Jo positive events hue, jo achhe actions liye, jo positive experiences aaye -woh income. Jo kuch hua jisme positivity kam hui, kuch negative aaya -woh expense. Aur net mein agar positive zyada raha -net profit -toh tera soul power badhta hai. Tera confidence badhta hai. Teri personality strong hoti hai. Aura achha hota hai. Aur agar negative zyada raha -toh woh sab kam hota hai.

Arjun: Soul power?

Pranav Bhaiya: Equity. Ek insaan ki apni net worth -jo assets minus liabilities ke baad bachti hai. Woh uski asli pehchaan hai. Uski soch, uska attitude, uski ideology, uski personality -yeh sab uski equity hai. Uska soul power hai. Isliye kehte hain -achhe experiences badhate raho, bure kam karo. Kyunki net positive rehne se equity badhti hai. Teri asli value badhti hai.

(Arjun is quiet, absorbing this.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Ab balance sheet. Ek company ka balance sheet financial year ke end pe zero se shuru nahi hota. Pichle saal ke assets carry forward hote hain, liabilities carry forward hoti hain, equity carry forward hoti hai. Opening balance hota hai.

Arjun: Haan -closing balance becomes opening balance.

Pranav Bhaiya: Exactly. Ab socho -ek insaan. Jab woh is life mein aata hai -kya woh zero se shuru karta hai?

(Arjun pauses. This is new territory.)

Arjun: Log kehte hain -pichle janmon ke karm saath laate hain.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. Woh opening balance hai. Past lives ka closing balance -is life ka opening balance ban jaata hai. Ek insaan zero se shuru nahi karta. Woh apne accumulated deeds lekar aata hai. Kuch log achhe opening balance ke saath aate hain -unke paas zyada assets hote hain shuru se. Kuch log debt mein aate hain -liabilities zyada hoti hain. Yeh unka opening balance sheet hai.

Arjun: *(slowly)* Toh jo log kehte hain "bhagya" -woh actually opening balance ki baat kar rahe hain.

Pranav Bhaiya: Ek tarah se haan. Par yeh sirf opening balance hai — poori kahani nahi. *(pause)* Ab yeh bata -jo events aur experiences tere saath hote hain is life mein -kya woh tere haath mein hain?

Arjun: Matlab? Kuch hota hai jo main control nahi kar sakta.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan. COVID aaya -tune control nahi kiya. Kisi ka accident ho jaata hai -usne control nahi kiya. Yeh events hain -ho sakta hai past deeds ki wajah se ho rahe hon, ho sakta hai destiny ki wajah se. Tere haath mein nahi hain necessarily.

Arjun: Toh phir?

Pranav Bhaiya: Par jo action tu leta hai -woh hamesha tere haath mein hai. Hamesha. Bina exception ke. *(pause)* Tujhe yaad hai -class 10 mein tune ek competition jeeta tha? State level. ₹5000 ka prize mila tha.

Arjun: *(smiling slightly)* Haan. Achhe se yaad hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Woh ₹5000 milna -woh event tha. Ho sakta hai tere past deeds ki wajah se mila. Ho sakta hai tune mehnat ki isliye mila. Woh discussion alag hai. Par ab woh ₹5000 tere haath mein aa gaye -ab kya karta hai — yeh sirf tera decision hai. Sirf tera.

Arjun: Haan.

Pranav Bhaiya: Agar tu dosto ke saath party karne chala gaya -ek accumulation. Ek alag result. Aur agar tune woh ₹5000 se koi course liya — AI ka, ya koi skill -toh ek alag accumulation. Alag future. Events tere haath mein nahi -actions hamesha tere haath mein hain.

Arjun: Toh free will vs destiny —

Pranav Bhaiya: Dono sach hain apni jagah. Agar tu free will mein believe karta hai -toh P&L ki har line tera apna action hai, tune choose kiya. Agar tu destiny mein believe karta hai -toh woh events the jo hone hi the, tujhe sirf jeena tha unhe. Par dono cases mein -accumulation hamesha tere haath mein hai. Yeh choice kabhi nahi jaati. Tujhe milti hi milti hai -kaise carry karna hai apne deeds ko.

(Arjun looks out the window for a moment. A passing truck's headlights sweep across his face briefly.)

Arjun: Aur cash flow statement? Insaan ka woh kya hoga?

Pranav Bhaiya: Sabse honest statement. Jo actually hua -ground pe, real world mein. Soch -teri niyat achhi thi, sochta achha tha, plan bada tha -par tune kiya kya? Jo actual action tha, jo actual karma tha -woh cash flow hai. Niyat fake ho sakti hai. Thought fake ho sakti hai. Action kabhi fake nahi hota. Jo tune actually kiya - woh hamesha sach hota hai.

Arjun: *(quietly)* Isliye kehte hain -karma karta hai toh phir milta hai. Jo actually kiya wahi count hota hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Bilkul. Ek business ka bhi sach yahi hai. P&L mein profit dikha sakti hai company -par cash flow negative ho toh sach samajh jaao. Jaise ek insaan ke achhe intentions ho sakte hain -par agar actions nahi hain toh kuch nahi hota. Cash flow hamesha sach bolta hai. Business mein bhi, life mein bhi.

(A long easy silence. The bus is nearly empty now. Just a few passengers left, sitting far apart, each in their own world. The road outside is dark except for occasional streetlights passing like slow pulses.)

Arjun: *(after a while)* Bhaiya -toh basically jo main samjha —

Pranav Bhaiya: Bol.

Arjun: Balance sheet mera accumulated hai -jo maine pichli lives se carry kiya, jo is life mein add kiya. P&L is life ka journey hai -kya achha hua, kya nahi hua, net mein kya nikla. Aur cash flow -woh jo maine actually kiya. Ground pe. Real actions.

Pranav Bhaiya: Aur teeno ek doosre se connected hain. P&L ka net result balance sheet mein jaata hai - reserves badhte hain ya kam hote hain. Cash flow batata hai ki P&L aur balance sheet ke numbers ke peeche actually kya hua tha.

Arjun: *(almost to himself)* Ek poor accounting system -ek insaan ki poori zindagi ke liye bhi kaam karta hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Isliye kaha tha -yeh universe ka niyam hai. Business ki language mein likha hua. Insaan ki life mein bhi wahi niyam hai. Dono alag nahi hain.

(Outside, the road is quiet and dark. The bus rocks gently. Arjun is leaning back in the window seat, looking up slightly -not at anything specific. Just up.)

What's the Point If I've Already Failed

(The bus is nearly empty. The road outside is dark. Arjun has been quiet for a while -a comfortable quiet. Then something shifts. His face changes slightly. The thought of his exam comes back.)

Arjun: *(after a long silence, quietly)* Bhaiya.

Pranav Bhaiya: Haan.

Arjun: Yeh sab -jo aapne bataya -bahut achha laga. Sach mein. Pehli baar accounts ka kuch sense bana mere liye. Aur woh nation building wali line -ab samajh aaya ki woh empty nahi thi. *(pause)* Par Bhaiya -kya faayda. Agar is exam mein main fail hi ho gaya toh? Sab samajh bhi gaya toh kya. Result toh wahi aayega jo aayega.

(Silence.)

Arjun: Matlab -aaj jo paper hua. Woh achha nahi gaya. Aur agar result nahi aaya -toh phir kya? Phir se ek saal. Phir se wahi. Main already peeche hoon sab se. Aur agar phir bhi nahi hua toh —

(He stops. Doesn't finish. Outside a streetlight passes. Then darkness again.)

(Pranav Bhaiya is quiet for a moment. Not thinking of what to say -just letting Arjun finish being in that feeling.)

Pranav Bhaiya: *(slowly)* Arjun -ek cheez poochhni thi.

Arjun: Haan.

Pranav Bhaiya: Tune jo padha is baar -apne end se -kya woh tera best version tha? Sach mein bata.

Arjun: *(pause)* Best toh nahi tha. Thoda aur kar sakta tha maybe. Par -itna padha pehle kabhi nahi tha. Bilkul naya concept tha. Ratt ke bhi kiya, bina samjhe bhi kiya, par time diya. Sach mein bahut time diya. Satisfied hoon apni mehnat se.

Pranav Bhaiya: Toh enough. *(quietly but clearly)* More than enough.

Arjun: Par result —

Pranav Bhaiya: Arjun. Tere haath mein kya tha?

Arjun: *(slowly)* Mehnat. Action. Padhai.

Pranav Bhaiya: Aur result?

(A beat.)

Arjun: *(quietly)* Mere haath mein nahi.

Pranav Bhaiya: Kabhi tha? Kisi ka bhi hota hai?

(Arjun doesn't answer. He already knows.)

Pranav Bhaiya: *(after a pause)* Tune abhi ek bahut important cheez boli -"kya faayda samajhne ka agar fail ho gaya." Yeh sawaal tune poochha. Aur is sawaal ka ek hi jawab hai jo bahut saalo pehle ek book me diya ja chuka hai. *(pause)* Tujhe pata hai tera naam kahan se aaya?

Arjun: *(confused)* Matlab?

Pranav Bhaiya: Arjun. Tera naam jesa hi Mahabharata mein bhi ek Arjun tha. Aur usne bhi yahi sawaal poochha tha apne waqt mein -kya faayda ladhne ka agar itna kuch kho jaayega? Kya faayda karm karne ka agar result pata nahi?

(Arjun goes still.)

Pranav Bhaiya: *(quietly)*

Karmanyevadhikaraste ma phaleshu kadachana. Ma karma phala hetur bhur ma te sango'stv akarmani.

(A pause. Just the sound of the bus engine.)

Pranav Bhaiya: Tera adhikar sirf apne karm pe hai. Result pe kabhi nahi tha. Karm ko result ke liye mat kar - aur akarm mein bhi mat reh. Bas karta reh. Yeh Krishna ne Arjun ko kaha tha uss din. Aur tera naam bhi Arjun hai -mujhe hamesha se yeh appropriate laga.

(Long silence. The bus rocks slightly on an uneven patch of road.)

Arjun: *(very quietly, almost a whisper)* Toh result ki chinta nahi karni.

Pranav Bhaiya: Result tera kaam nahi hai. Tera kaam sirf yeh hai ki kal se tu phir se baithega -aur padhai karega. Woh tera action hai. Woh tere haath mein hai. Baaki sab -universe ke haath mein hai.

(Arjun leans his head back slightly against the window. Eyes open. Just breathing.)

(A minute passes. Maybe more.)

Arjun: *(softly)* Theek hai Bhaiya. *(pause)* Ab theek lag raha hai. Sach mein. *(small pause)* Aur woh kahani -jo shuru mein sunane wale the. Socrates wali. Woh bhi sunao na bhaiya.. Ab man kar raha hai.

Pranav Bhaiya: *(a quiet laugh)* Haan. Woh agli baar sunaunga -abhi ek kaam hai. Office ka meeting hai ek, jaana padega.

Arjun: chha ,, Theek Hai bhaiya .

Pranav Bhaiya: Theek hai. Aur Arjun —

Arjun: Haan?

Pranav Bhaiya: *(simply)* Padhai karta reh.

(The call ends.)

The Road Home

(The phone goes dark in Arjun's hand. He keeps it there for a moment, screen down on his lap.)

(The bus is almost empty now. The bus once filled with people and the rush, is now so calm and quiet. One old man near the front, a woman with a sleeping child two rows back. That's it. Everyone else has gotten off somewhere along the way.)

(Outside -it is properly night now. But not city night. This is the outskirts. Open fields on both sides of the road. A few distant lights from houses far away. The sky above is very large and very dark and has more stars than the city ever shows.)

(The window is open. Cool air is coming in steadily. Arjun closes his eyes for a moment.)

(The mental chatter -the noise that had been running since he walked out of that exam hall -is gone. Not because anything got resolved. The result is still unknown. The paper is still what it was. Nothing changed.)

(And yet -quiet.)

(He sits with that for a while. Just that.)

Home

(The bus stops. Arjun gets off.)

(He walks the last few minutes to his house. The lane is quiet. A dog somewhere. The smell of someone cooking dinner.)

(He had decided, somewhere between the exam hall and the bus stand, that he was going to tell his parents tonight. That this was a mistake. That he needed to switch. That CA was not for him. He had the whole conversation planned in his head.)

(He opens the door.)

(His mother is in the kitchen. His father is watching the news. Someone has already set the table.)

Arjun's mother: Aa gaya? Khaana lag jaaye?

Arjun: Haan Maa. *(puts his bag down)* Aa raha hoon.

(He washes his hands. Sits down at the table. His father comes and sits across. His mother brings the food.)

Arjun's father: *(casually)* Paper kaisa gaya?

(A pause. Just one second.)

Arjun: *(simply)* Theek tha. Dekho ab result kya aata hai. Jo hoga achha hoga.

(His father nods. His mother says something about eating while it's hot. The television murmurs from the other room.)

(Arjun eats.)

(The conversation he had planned -the one about switching, about wrong decisions, about feeling worthless -it doesn't come. Not because he forgot. Not because he's pretending.

Because right now, in this moment, sitting here -he doesn't need it to.)

(He eats his dinner. He goes to sleep.)

(The result will come when it comes.)

-End of Chapter 0 —